ZIMBABWE INSTITUTE OF DIPLOMACY

"Centre for Excellence in Diplomacy"

CONFLICT RESOLUTION

"Conflict is the gadfly of thought. It stirs us to observation and memory. It instigates invention. It shocks us out of sheep-like passivity, and sets us at noting and contriving conflict is a 'sine qua non' of reflection and ingenuity."
John Dewey

CONFLICT

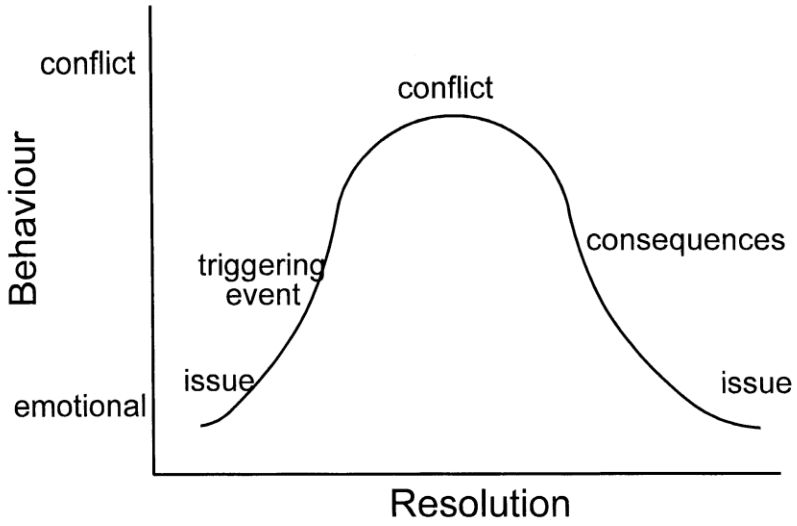
Definition and scope

- Opposition, Incompatible behavior, Antagonistic interaction

Types of conflict

- Interpersonal
- Intragroup
- Intergroup
- Intra-organisation
- Inter-organisation

Conflict Cycle



Thomas-Kilmann Conflict Styles



Thomas-Kilmann Conflict Styles

- Avoiding (Uncooperative and unassertive) Neglects own concerns as well as those of other parties: does not raise or address conflict issues.
- Accommodating (Cooperative and unassertive) Seeks to satisfy other person's concerns at the expense of own.

- Competing (Uncooperative and assertive) Opposite of accommodating. Uses whatever seems appropriate to win.

Thomas-Kilmann Conflict Styles

- Collaborating (Cooperative and assertive) Opposite of avoiding. Works with other party to find a solution that satisfies both own and other party's concerns.
- Compromising (Middle ground) Seeks to find a middle ground to partially satisfy both parties.

When to Avoid

- When an issue is trivial.
- When there is no chance of getting what you want.
- When the potential damage of confrontation is greater than the benefits if resolution.
- When you need to gather more information.
- When others can resolve the conflict more effectively.
- When you need to cool down, reduce tension, and regain perspective or composure.

When to Accommodate

- When you realize you are wrong.
- When the issue is much more important to the other person than you.
- When you need a future favor (credit).
- When continuing the competition would damage the cause.
- When subordinates need to develop - to learn from our mistakes.

When to Compete

- When quick, decisive action is necessary.
- On important issues for which unpopular courses of action need implementing.
- On issues vital to the group welfare, when you know you are right.
- When protection is needed against people who take advantage of noncompetitive behavior.

When to Collaborate

- When both sets of concerns are too important to be compromised.

- When it is necessary to test your assumptions or better to understand the viewpoint of the other party.
- When there is a need to combine ideas from people with different perspectives.
- When commitment can be increased by incorporating the concerns of everyone into the proposal.
- When there is a history of bad feeling.

When to Compromise

- When goals are important but not worth the effort of potential disruption from more aggressive players.
- When two opponents with equal power are strongly committed to mutually exclusive goals.
- When temporary settlements are needed on complex issues.
- When expedient solutions are needed under time pressures.
- As back-up when collaboration or competition fail.

Negative Consequences of Competing

- Eventually being surrounded by "yes people."
- Fear of admitting error, ignorance, or uncertainty.
- Reduced communication.
- Damaged relationships.
- Lack of commitment from others.
- More effort during implementation to sell the solution.

Negative Consequences of Collaborating

- Too much time spent on insignificant issues.
- Ineffective decisions can be made by people with limited knowledge of the situation.
- Unfounded assumptions about trust.

Negative Consequences of Compromising

- No one is completely satisfied.
- Solutions tend to be short-lived.
- Cynical climate: perception by both parties that it is a "sellout."

- Larger issues, principles, long-term values and the welfare of the company can be lost by focusing on trivia or the practicality of implementation.

Negative Consequences of Avoiding

- Decisions made by default.
- Unresolved issues.
- Self-doubt created through lack of esteem.
- Creative input lost.
- Lack of credibility.
- Anger and hostility generated in subsequent discussions.

Negative Consequences of Accommodating

- Decreased influence, respect, or recognition by too much deference.
- Laxity in discipline.
- Frustration as own needs are not met.
- Self-esteem undermined.
- Best solution may be lost.

Levels of conflict

- **INFORMAL**: More often handled quickly, less noticeable by others;
- **FORMAL**: Needs more attention; more skills necessary to resolve or understand

KEY COMPONENTS IN RESOLVING CONFLICT

- GREAT listening skills
- Flexibility
- Willingness to change
- Agree to disagree

LISTENING SKILLS

- Maintain eye contact
- Do not interrupt; let them finish
- Good posture – maintain a non-threatening position
- Mentally rehearse situations in which you might become emotional

FLEXIBILITY

- Be able to adjust to any situation
- Do not try to handled the situation alone; use your partner(s)
- Understand you are not going to please everyone; agree to disagree; this is a two way street, but the official has the final say

WILLINGNESS TO CHANGE

- If change is necessary, make the change
- Be driven by the TEAM mindset
- Appreciate diversity- we are different

Levels of conflict resolution

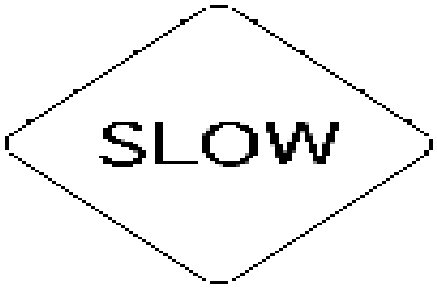
- **Negotiating** - two individuals sit down and work out a resolution together
- **Mediation** - a third party assists individuals in finding a solution
- **Arbitration** - instituted when negotiations and mediations fail

Rules of the Road:



No "You" statements. Use statements that begin with the word "I". Do not use statements that include the word "you," because these statements make people feel defensive.





Slow. Remember, it takes time to settle a conflict. Go slow at first, because conflict resolvers usually encounter some rough roads in the beginning. Keep using your I-way map to reach safer roads.



Detour Ahead. Sometimes tempers are flaring so much that it may be necessary to take a temporary detour from the communication I-way.

Once the tempers have calmed down, you may begin using I statements to solve the problem.



Merge Ahead.

After using properly constructed statements, individuals can begin to share ideas for how to solve the problem. Often, the best solution is reached when two people merge their ideas together.



End of Construction. After reaching a solution that the two individuals agree will work, they can resume normal activities